



NVIDIA 9600GT Galore!

More For Less

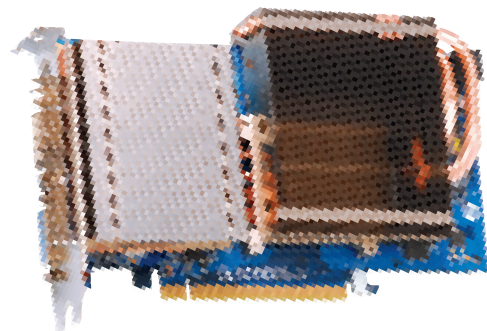
The mid-range graphics card market is abuzz with new releases that promise never-before-seen performance at reasonable price. These new value warriors had us gasping in disbelief. With the 8800GT and 8800GTS (512 MB) both priced above 10K, the 9600GT fits the “affordable gamer card” bill perfectly.

Based on the newer G94 core, the 9600GT is similar to the G92-based 8800GT and 8800GTS cards. However, the stream processors (SP) have been halved on this new budget card. The stock clock speeds are 650 MHz for the GPU core, the memory running at 900 MHz (1,800 actual) and the SPs humming at 1,625 MHz.

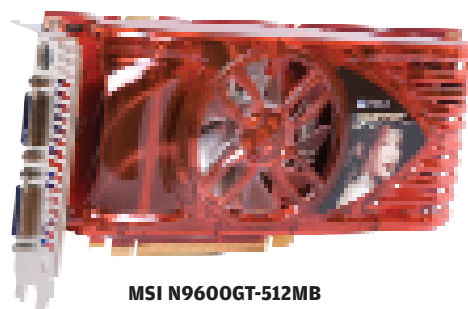
We have five cards from XFX, MSI, ASUS, Sparkle and Gigabyte. Though based on the same chipset, these cards sported various designs. ASUS, Sparkle and XFX were based around the NVIDIA reference, single slot design. MSI has the most spectacular looking card, where as Gigabyte had resorted to their passive-cooled heat pipe

design. Both these cards require two slots though.

During our testing, the single slot cards got warmer. However, the temperatures were within acceptable limits and we could touch the card. The heat pipes on the Gigabyte card did an excellent job, although the fins got really hot. The MSI card with its unique heat pipe plus fan design kept cool throughout the test.



Gigabyte GV-NX96T 512HP



MSI N9600GT-512MB



Sparkle SF-PX96GT512D3-HP



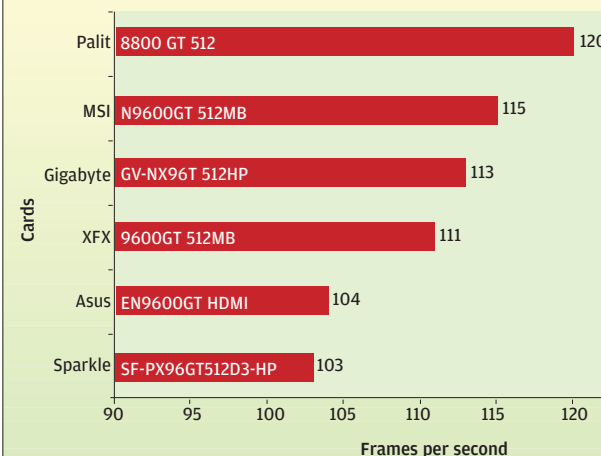
XFX 9600GT 512MB



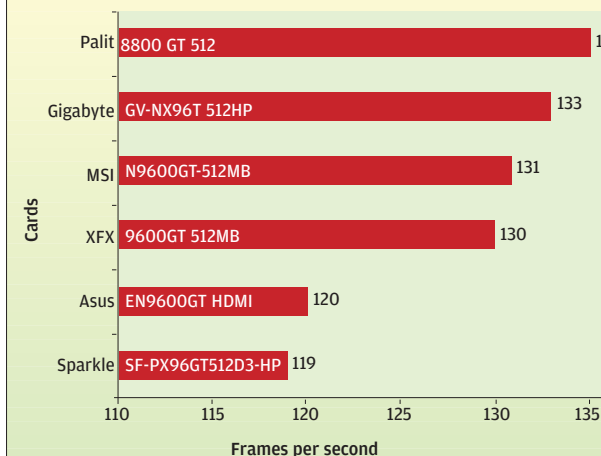
ASUS EN9600GT HDMI

Ratings and Contacts	Sparkle SF-PX96GT512D3-HP	Gigabyte GV-NX96T 512HP	MSI N9600GT-512MB	XFX 9600GT 512MB	ASUS EN9600GT HDMI
Features	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●
Performance	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●
Build Quality	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●
Value For Money	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●	★★★★●
Price	Rs 10,500	Rs 15,900	Rs 13,000	Rs 11,900	12,600
E-mail	megha@abacusperipherals.com	sales@gigabyte.in	sanyam@msi-in.com	xfx@rptechindia.com	media_india@asus.com
Phone	+91-22-40914613	+91-22-23823331 / 2	+91-11-41758808 / 09	+91-22-67090909	+91-22-67668800

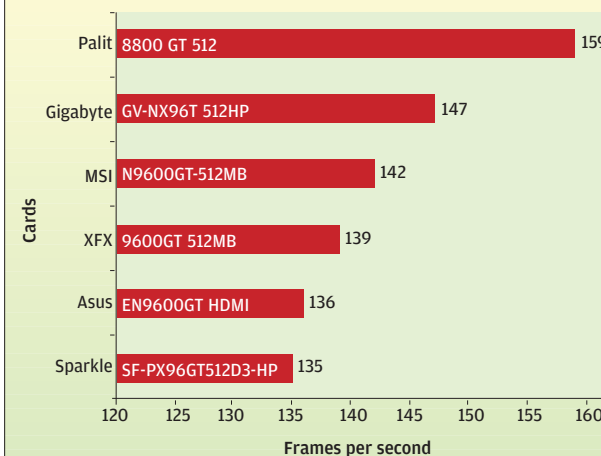
Prey @ 1280x1024 (4AA, 4AF)



Doom 3 @ 1280x1024 (4AA, 4AF)



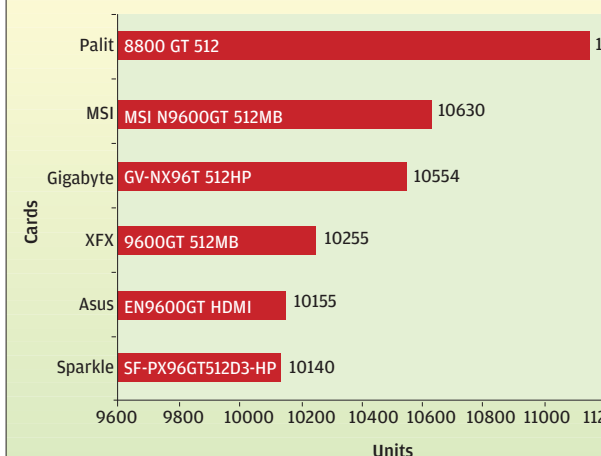
Splinter Cell Chaos Theory @ 1280x1024 (4AA, 4AF)



Almost all cards supported HDMI connectivity, which is good. However, this is done via the DVI-to-HDMI connector. Some higher-end 9600GTs have them on the back panel.

The XFX 9600GT comes bundled with the *Company of Heroes* game, necessary cables and HDMI connector. MSI, ASUS, Sparkle and Gigabyte cards come with an HDMI connector, cables

3DMark 2006



and the quick install guide—but no free games.

On the performance front, the MSI and Gigabyte cards were neck and neck. Other cards were trailing behind. All 9600GT cards are within a hairs-breadth of the 8800GT card. At lower resolutions, the difference isn't noticeable, in fact in some benchmarks the 9600GT runs at par with the 8800GT. However at higher resolutions, the performance gap widens. Gigabyte's 9600GT returned the best results across the board with MSI following closely at its heels. Gigabyte has priced its card at nearly Rs 16,000. At that

price, one can buy an 8800GT. MSI is sweetly priced at Rs 13,000 and offers the best buy for the buck, considering the slight performance edge it has over other cards. XFX has the best bundle, good performance and is reasonably priced. Sparkle offers the best of both worlds—decent performance at a terrific price.

Specifications

Core clock 650 MHz, 1,800 MHz memory clock, 512 MB GDDR3, 256-bit memory interface, 1,625 MHz shader clock, PCI express 2.0, 400 MHz RAMDAC and HDMI connectivity.